

21st Annual African Vaccinology Course (AAVC)



Independent Selection Committee – Online Screening & Scoring Manual (2026)

Thank you for accepting the invitation to serve on the Independent Selection Committee for the **21st Annual African Vaccinology Course (AAVC)**. Your thorough and objective evaluation is critical to ensuring a balanced, diverse, and high-calibre participant cohort for this milestone course.

For the 2026 intake, we have transitioned from manual Excel spreadsheets and OneDrive folders to the dedicated **AAVC Database & Online Screening Portal**. This portal centralizes all applications, document links, automated scoring rubrics, and country ranking leaderboards in one secure web platform.

Key Information & Support

- **Screening Timeline:** Please complete all evaluations for your assigned cohorts within the allocated review window.
- **Support Contacts:** Should you experience any technical issues accessing the portal, opening document links, or questions about selection criteria, please reach out to:
 - **Alana Keyser:** alana.keyser@uct.ac.za
 - **Edina Amponsah-Dacosta:** edina.amponsah-dacosta@uct.ac.za

Part 1: How to Log In & Navigate the Portal

1. Portal Access & Initial Login

1. Open the **AAVC Screening Portal** URL in your web browser (*Google Chrome, Microsoft Edge, or Safari recommended*).
2. On the white **Alumni & Screener Login card** in the center of your screen, enter your credentials:
 - **Email Address:** Enter your registered email address exactly (*e.g., yournamehereorstudentnumber@uct.ac.za*).
 - **Password:** Your initial login password has been pre-configured to be your **exact email address in all lowercase letters** (*e.g., yournamehereorstudentnumber@uct.ac.za*).
 - (*Note: The portal features smart case-sensitivity handling, so typing your email or password with capital letters will automatically log you in cleanly*).
3. Click the **Red Log In button** located at the bottom of the login card. You will be taken immediately to your personalized **Screening Workspace**.

2. Understanding Your Screening Workspace Layout

Once logged in, your workspace is organized into three main sections:

1. Top Control & View Bar:

- **Select Cohort / Province Dropdown:** Located at the top left next to *Screening Year: AAVC 2026*. Click this dropdown to select the specific country/cohort you want to review (*e.g., Algeria, Nigeria, SA-WC*).
- **Progress Bar:** Displays real-time progress for your selected cohort (*e.g., Progress for Algeria: 0 / 1 Scored*).
- **View Mode Buttons (Top Right):**
 - Review & Score Queue (*Active default view for reviewing individual candidates*)
 - Cohort Ranking Table (*Switch to view the full sorted leaderboard once scoring is done*)
 - Export Cohort Excel (*Export cohort data*)

2. Left Sidebar (**Applicant Queue**):

- Contains a search bar (*Search applicant...*) and a status filter dropdown.
- Lists all applicants belonging to the selected cohort as individual white cards showing their name, institution, and decision status pill (*e.g., PENDING in yellow*).

- **Clicking any applicant's card on the left sidebar** loads their complete profile and scoring card into the main right window.
3. **Main Right Window (*Application Info, Documents & Scoring*):**
- Displays the selected candidate's full profile cards, uploaded document buttons, and scoring card.
-

Part 2: Step-by-Step Screening & Scoring Workflow

Step 1 – Select Applicant & Review Background Info

1. Select your assigned cohort from the **Select Cohort / Province** dropdown at the top.
 2. Click an applicant's card on the **left sidebar** to load their file into the main right window.
 3. **Review Summary Cards (*Shown Directly on Screen*):** You do not need to open a separate application form file. The candidate's information is displayed directly on the screen across four summary cards:
 - **Demographics & Contact:** DOB, Gender, Nationality, Residence, Mobile.
 - **Professional & Institution:** Current Position, Institution Name & Address, Highest Education.
 - **Vaccinology & NITAG Background:** Shows **Previous AAVC** attendance answer (Yes/No), NITAG membership, English proficiency, and other courses.
 - **Line Manager Information:** Supervisor Name, Email, and Phone Contact.
 4. **Outright Rejection Rule (Prior Attendance):** Check the **Previous AAVC** field under *Vaccinology & NITAG Background*. If it is confirmed that the applicant has attended AAVC in person before, scroll down to the bottom scoring card, select **Yes (-1 pt - DQ)** under *Attended AAVC previously?* Set the **Decision** dropdown to **Reject**, enter a comment stating, "Previously attended course", and click the **large red Save & Record Score button**. You do not need to score the remaining criteria. If they have **not** attended in person, proceed to Step 2.
-

Step 2 – Open & Verify Uploaded Supporting Documents

In the middle section of the main window under **Uploaded Supporting Documents (Click to Open in New Tab)**, click the buttons to open each submitted document in a new browser tab:

- **Open Abridged CV (Inline):** Verify that the CV is **strictly maximum 2 pages**.
- **Open Motivation Letter (Inline):** Verify that the Motivation Letter is **strictly maximum 1 page**.
- **Open HOD Support Letter (Inline):** Verify that the Recommendation/Support Letter is **strictly maximum 1 page**.

Document Length Discretion & Rejection Rule:

- **Within Limits / Slightly Over:** If all three documents are within the required page limits (*use your discretion if a document is just a little over*), proceed with scoring the rest of the application.
- **Excessively Long Documents:** If the documents are excessively long and the rules of document length have not been adhered to, use your discretion to reject the applicant. Set the **Decision** dropdown to **Reject** and enter a custom comment stating why they were rejected (e.g., *"CV is over 10 pages; exceeds document length rules"*).

Step 3 – Score the Rubric Criteria

Scroll down to the **Scoring Card** at the **bottom of the main window**. Click the round radio buttons to assign points for each criterion based on the official AAVC scoring guidelines. The running total (*Maximum possible: 7 points*) will update automatically:

Rubric Criterion	Point Options & Selection Guidance
1. Attended AAVC Previously?	• No (+1 pt): Candidate has not attended AAVC before. • Yes (-1 pt - Automatic Rejection): Candidate previously attended in person.
2. Current Position & Involvement	• 2 pts: Works directly in human vaccine research or immunization systems. • 1 pt: Works indirectly in human vaccine research (e.g., <i>general health-related or public health field</i>). • 0 pts: Non-human vaccine work (e.g., <i>veterinary vaccines</i>) or non-vaccine work.

Rubric Criterion	Point Options & Selection Guidance
3. Curriculum Vitae (CV)	• 1 pt: CV is strictly maximum 2 pages AND clearly demonstrates current involvement or a clear career pathway toward involvement in vaccines/immunization systems. • 0 pts: Exceeds 2 pages OR lacks relevance to vaccines/immunization.
4. Motivation Letter	• 1 pt: Letter is strictly maximum 1 page AND clearly demonstrates strong need for training (<i>capacity to benefit</i>) as well as the ability to contribute during and after AAVC (e.g., <i>transmitting learnings to colleagues/institution</i>). • 0 pts: Exceeds 1 page OR lacks compelling motivation/justification.
5. Recommendation Letter	• 1 pt: Letter is strictly maximum 1 page, ideally from their direct line manager/supervisor, written on official signed letterhead, and strongly recommends the candidate with concrete evidence. • 0 pts: Exceeds 1 page, unofficial/unsigned, or weak support.
6. Completeness & Alignment	• 1 pt: All three required documents (<i>CV, Motivation Letter, Recommendation Letter</i>) are present, complete, and strictly adhere to all page limits. • 0 pts: Any document missing or violating page guidelines.

Step 4 – Select Standardized Comments & Add Notes

Below the rubric criteria on the scoring card, click one or more of the colored badges in the **Multi-Select Comments Bank** to attach standardized feedback, or type custom notes in the text box right below:

-  **Acceptance / High Priority Presets (Green Badges):**
 - Directly involved in national immunization program
 - Strong application – high potential & clear pathway
 - High capacity to benefit & transmit learnings
 - Excellent institutional recommendation
-  **Review / Reserve Pool Presets (Yellow/Amber Badges):**
 - Good qualifications but needs more practical vaccine exposure

- Strong clinical background; indirect vaccine involvement
 - Meets criteria; placed on reserve list
 -  **Rejection / Disqualification Presets (*Red Badges*):**
 - Weak application – lacks relevant experience
 - Non-human/veterinary vaccine focus
 - Incomplete documents or exceeds strict page limits
 - Previously attended course
-

Step 5 – Save Score & Initial Decision (*Crucial Step*)

1. **Assign Decision:** Using the **Decision** dropdown at the bottom of the scoring card, select Accept, Pending / Reserve, or Reject.
 2. Click the **large red Save & Record Score button** at the bottom of the scoring card. This saves your score and evaluation to the database and marks the applicant as scored.
-

Part 3: Finalizing Country Rankings & Selection Rules

Once you have evaluated and clicked **Save** for **all applicants within a country cohort**:

1. **Switch to the Leaderboard View:** Click the **Cohort Ranking Table button** located at the top right of the header control bar.
2. **Review the Sorted Leaderboard:** The table displays all applicants in the cohort automatically sorted from highest score to lowest score and by decision priority.
3. **Assign Sequential Ranks:** Input their numerical ranking (1, 2, 3, 4, etc.) into the **Rank in Country** box for each applicant.
 - **CRITICAL: You must rank ALL applicants from the same cohort sequentially (1 to N)**, including rejected or reserve candidates! This numerical ranking allows the committee to immediately extend invitations to the next-highest ranked candidate (#3, #4, etc.) if a top-ranked applicant (#1 or #2) is unable to attend.

Official Acceptance Quotas per Country:

- **Rank #1 Candidate** → (*Prioritized for In-Person Attendance*).

- **Rank #2 Candidate** → (*Prioritized for **Online Attendance**, or in-person if the candidate is exceptionally strong and funding permits*).
- **Rank #3 and lower** → Ensure their numerical rank (3, 4, 5, etc.) is recorded so they can serve as alternates.
- **Single-Applicant Countries:** If there is only one applicant from an assigned cohort, conduct the full screening process and recommend **Accept** (*Rank 1*) if they meet the criteria, or **Reject** if they do not meet the minimum threshold.

Thank you once again for your dedication, expertise, and contribution to the Annual African Vaccinology Course!